MEMBER GUIDES · C6E

Your year as Junior Warden

Your first year as a principal officer: a chair, a column, the Festive Board, and the first year that counts towards the Chair. A short guide.

For	The Brother about to be invested as Junior Warden, and his Personal Mentor
Issue	Issue 1 (Draft for Review), October 2026 · One of six Officer Guides, Steward to Senior Warden. The office is described here; the words and floorwork are learned at the Lodge of Instruction, never from a document.

1 What the office is

The Junior Warden sits in the South. In the Lodge room he has set responses in the opening and closing, calls the Brethren from labour to refreshment and back again, and in many Lodges proves visiting Brethren before a meeting. Outside the Lodge room he is responsible for the Festive Board: the catering, the seating, the Stewards and the comfort of guests. With the Master and the Senior Warden he is one of the three principal officers, and a full year as a Warden, Installation to Installation, is what makes a Brother eligible for the Chair.

Your jewel	The plumb rule, the emblem of uprightness. You will also have a gavel, and a column that stands or lies according to whether the Lodge is at labour or refreshment.

2 What you will actually do

- Learn your responses in the openings and closings of all three degrees, and the calling off and on. Short pieces, but there are many of them, and they come every meeting.
- Take charge of the Festive Board with the Stewards: numbers, dietary needs, seating that mixes new members in, visitors looked after, and the toast list agreed with the DC.
- Learn to prove a visitor, if your Lodge gives that duty to the Junior Warden. The DC will teach you.
- Prepare and practise your Festive Board toast; it is part of the office in most Lodges.
- Be ready, if asked, to work a First Degree ceremony in the Chair during your year. Many Lodges give the Junior Warden an Initiation; the DC will say if yours does.
- Visit with a purpose: other Lodges' Installations build the contacts that fill your own.

3 What to learn, and how

- Your words come at every meeting, so they settle quickly. The craft of this year is managing people: Stewards, caterers, visitors.
- If you are to work a First Degree, start now. The Preceptor and the DC will build you a plan.
- Read the By-laws and the summons with new eyes: next year you plan a year, and the year after it is yours.
- Little and often. Ten minutes a day, out loud, beats an hour on the night before.

4 Things nobody tells you

- The Festive Board tone is yours to set from the South. "Look who's remembered where we meet" gets said, or not, depending on the officers at the top table.
- A first missed subscription, a Brother who always leaves before the toasts, a Steward who has stopped coming: you will see these before the Almoner does. Tell the Lodge Mentor.

- Rule 105a: a Warden must serve a full year, Installation to Installation, to be eligible for the Chair. If you were invested at a later meeting, speak to the Secretary now about a dispensation.

5 The time it takes

One meeting a month, the Lodge of Instruction most weeks, the Festive Board arrangements between meetings, and a growing number of visits. This is where the diary fills. Family, Work, Masonry, in that order; say so to the Master if it is becoming too much.

6 Who will help

Your Personal Mentor	Still yours. Office does not end mentoring; it changes the conversation. Tell him if the learning is not going well, or the diary.
The Director of Ceremonies	Owns the ceremonies and the floor. He will tell you what your Lodge does, which is what matters; Lodges differ.
The Preceptor and the LoI	Where the office is learned. Go even in the weeks when there is nothing for you to do.
The Lodge Mentor	Watches the office queue for the whole Lodge: nobody pushed before he is ready, nobody left waiting. Say so to him if either is happening to you.
The Province	mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk, the monthly mentoring call on the first Tuesday at 7pm, and Solomon (solomon.ugle.org.uk), which has a paper on every office.

7 Looking ahead

Senior Warden: the understudy year, and the one in which you choose your team and plan your year in the Chair. The Province's session The Chair and Beyond is for you from here.

> **For your mentor.** Three questions for the conversation before the Installation: Does he want this office this year, and has he said so to his family? What is the one piece he is worried about, and who will help him with it? What will we do together in the second half of the year to make the next office feel easy?
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> **Readiness, not pressure, in either direction.** Nobody should take an office before he feels able, and nobody capable should be left waiting. Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.

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